

Cause Web Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 30-40 min

Category	History	Time	30-40 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	cause-web

Big idea: Causation is layered and contestable.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students investigate complex causation in historical explanation.

Student Prompt

Inspect Cause Web Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Cause Web Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A web of causes for a school rule change, historical event, or social movement. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Cause Web Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Cards sorted into trigger, background condition, actor, and consequence. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Cause Web Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A debate over whether one cause can be 'the' cause. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Causation is layered and contestable.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Cause Web Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Cause Web Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	How do historians decide which causes matter most?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to History.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how causation is layered and contestable.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: How do historians decide which causes matter most?

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: A web of causes for a school rule change, historical event, or social movement.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- A web of causes for a school rule change, historical event, or social movement.
- Cards sorted into trigger, background condition, actor, and consequence.
- A debate over whether one cause can be 'the' cause.

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/cause-web/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/cause-web/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/cause-web/visual-prompt.svg>
- Printable student worksheet with observation, inference, evidence, and confidence columns.
- Teacher notes with setup checklist, sample facilitation language, misconceptions, and assessment look-fors.
- Classroom run kit with prompt cards, example stimuli, and debrief moves.
- PowerPoint deck with a student-facing sequence for running the activity.

Run Sequence

1. Students create a web of causes.
2. They label causes as long-term, short-term, structural, individual, accidental or ideological.
3. They choose the three most important causes and justify their ranking.
4. Groups compare rankings.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: How do historians decide which causes matter most?
- Are historical events inevitable?
- What is the role of chance in historical knowledge?

Teacher Quick Script

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...